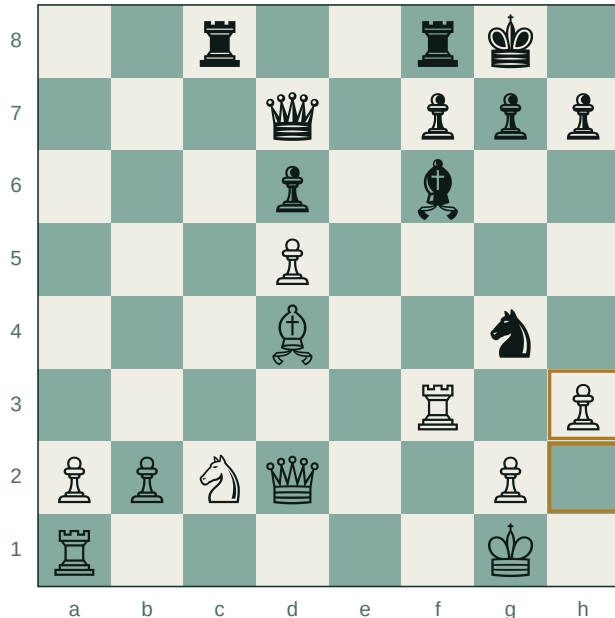


Capture the defender: Black, move 20

Capture the defender

Black to move



Previous move: 20.h3. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

20...Rxc2 21. Qxc2 Bxd4+

20...Rxc2 The rook captures the knight on c2. Recorded reply: **21.Qxc2**.

21...Bxd4+ Check restricts White to 5 legal replies here. The move also takes the bishop on d4.

At the end, nominal material is White 24 / Black 24 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +1. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +1:** the balance goes from -1 to +0. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on g1. Geometrically undefended: queen on d2. Check for tactical protection.